

KEY DEVELOPMENTS IN BRITISH DEMOCRACY

The fundamental principles of British life include:

- Democracy
- The rule of law
- Individual liberty

These ideas developed over time... but how much do you know about them?

EARLY BRITAIN

The Romans arrive. Over the next 400 years, they build roads, public buildings and create a structure of law

AD 43

THE MIDDLE AGES

In England, King John is forced by his noblemen to agree to a number of demands. The result is Magna Carta (Great Charter), a legal document that restricts the king's power to raise taxes or change laws. Parliaments are called for the king to consult his nobles. Magna Carta is often seen as the beginnings of constitutional democracy.

- A similar Parliament develops in Scotland.
- The idea that judges are independent of the government begins to be established.

1215

THE ENGLISH CIVIL WAR

King Charles I recalls Parliament to help him deal with problems in Scotland. Parliament refuses to give him money to raise an army, leading to the English Civil War. Parliament wins the war and in 1649, the king is executed.

1640

1649

THE ENGLISH REPUBLIC

England declares itself a republic. Oliver Cromwell is given the title of 'Lord Protector' and rules until his death in 1658.

THE RESTORATION

Parliament invites Charles II back from exile in the Netherlands. Charles accepts that he cannot always do as he wishes – sometimes he will need to involve Parliament in his decisions.

1660

1679

THE HABEAS CORPUS ACT

Parliament passes the Habeas Corpus Act. This very important piece of legislation remains relevant today. The act guarantees that nobody can be held prisoner unlawfully.

THE GLORIOUS REVOLUTION

King James flees to France. James did not seek to reach agreement with Parliament and arrests some bishops of the Church of England. Parliament invites William of Orange to invade England and proclaim himself king. The 'Glorious Revolution' involves no fighting and guarantees the power of Parliament.

A Declaration of Rights is read that confirms that the king will no longer be able to raise taxes or administer justice without agreement from Parliament.

The change means that the monarch is no longer able to govern without the help of ministers. This is the beginning of party politics.

1688

THE 18TH CENTURY

THE ENLIGHTENMENT

The idea that people should have a right to their own political and religious beliefs without interference from the state begins to grow.

THE GREAT REFORM ACT

Up until the 1830s, only wealthy landowners are allowed to vote. The growth of the middle classes leads to a demand for more political power. 'The Great Reform Act' greatly increases the number of people with the right to vote.

1832

1867

THE REFORM ACT

Another reform act creates many more urban seats. However the majority of men cannot vote and no women can vote.

1918 – THE REPRESENTATION OF THE PEOPLE ACT

Men over the age of 21 are given the right to vote, regardless of whether they own property or not. Many women still cannot vote.

THE 20TH CENTURY

1928

THE EQUAL FRANCHISE ACT

Women over the age of 21 are given the right to vote.